Kun Zhang

PhD Applicant — Large Language Models: Post-Training, Alignment, and Evaluation

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My work focuses on the evaluation, alignment and post-training of large language models.

Education

University of Leeds — Leeds, United Kingdom
MSc Advanced Computer Science — taught and assessed entirely in English — Sep 2025 – Sep 2026

- Dissertation: a leakage-controlled audit of whether financial text adds forecasting value beyond price and firm-level baselines.
- Selected module marks: Deep Learning **84** • Knowledge Representation & Reasoning **81** • Data Mining & Text Analytics **81** • Machine Learning **77**

Hunan University of Finance and Economics — Changsha, China
BSc Computer Science and Technology — Sep 2021 – Jun 2025

- Final-year project: GAN-based face image inpainting

Publications

All papers below are **first-authored**; five accepted, three under review. Papers marked † were co-authored with my MSc supervisor Dr Chunwei Xia as corresponding author; the remaining two are **sole-authored**. Venue ranks: ICORE2026 (CORE).

ACCEPTED

[1] K. Zhang, C. Xia†. *Same Exam, Different Scores: A Tokenizer-Grounded Audit of Evaluation-Protocol Sensitivity on Chinese Benchmarks.* **NLPCC 2026** (Resources and Evaluation track) — **Oral**, Springer LNCS.
Pre-registered from tokenizer properties which model–label pairs leave first-token-argmax scoring undefined; all 64 predictions held. Generative answering shifted rankings far beyond sampling noise, mainly via format non-compliance.

[2] K. Zhang, C. Xia†. *ProbeShift: Predicting Probe-Direction Rotation from Stability is Largely a Sampling-Noise Floor.* **ACML 2026** CORE C, conference track — **Oral**, PMLR.
A benchmark and a symmetric-null validity standard for probe-stability signals. ID-only stability predicts a probe's rotation under semantic shift at $\rho = 0.945$, yet scores *higher* on a zero-shift placebo ($\rho = 0.966$); of seven candidate signals only one survives the null.

[3] K. Zhang. *Grounding or Lexical Overlap? A Matched-Pair Study of Internals-Based Context-Faithfulness Probes.* **GroundLM 2026** (workshop at EMNLP) — workshop **Findings** track.
In the standard extractive setup the faithfulness label correlates with lexical overlap at $r = 0.99$, so a grounding probe can be a string matcher. A matched construction halves the confound ($r = 0.50$); on RAGTruth the probe direction scores below NLI and lexical overlap.

[4] K. Zhang, C. Xia†. *A Point-in-Time Audit of Graph-Snapshot Leakage in GNN Stock Selection.* **PRICAI 2026** CORE B — regular paper (12–16 pp.), **Oral**, Springer LNAI.
Rebuilt point-in-time co-holding graphs from raw SEC 13F filings. Two apparent leakage effects did not hold under seeds and degree-preserving nulls; the daily-snapshot edge came mainly from graph stability.

[5] K. Zhang. *PCP: A Controlled Benchmark for Pragmatic Intention Recognition in Clinical Communication.* **LUHME 2026** @ EMNLP — **Oral**.
A 3,533-item benchmark for recovering intended meaning from hedging, indirectness and implicature. Eleven systems sit near ceiling on the controlled split (98.7–99.8%) but fall to 79.7–90.6% on externally grounded cases, so a broad controlled probe can hide the difficulty that close distractors expose.

UNDER REVIEW

Three further first-author manuscripts are under review, two of them now in Phase 2; titles and venues are withheld during anonymous review.

Research Themes

- **LLM evaluation, alignment and post-training**: evaluation protocols and benchmarks [1] [5]; validity of probes on model internals [2] [3]; leakage and confounds in forecasting [4] [under review]; alignment and post-training [under review]

Industry Experience

Chinte Technology Changsha, China
AI Application Development (intern) — built a retrieval-augmented generation architecture Nov 2024 – Jun 2025

Guangdong Lianhe Information Technology China
Data Analysis (intern) — business data evaluation Feb 2024 – Aug 2024

Academic Service

Reviewer NLPCC 2026 (main conference) • GroundLM 2026 (workshop at EMNLP) • VLM4RWD 2026 (workshop at NeurIPS) 2026

Student member ACL • CCF (China Computer Federation)

Awards

- 2025 **International Excellence Scholarship** (£8,438), School of Computer Science, University of Leeds — tuition fee award for MSc Advanced Computer Science.
- May 2025 **Inspiring Excellence Scholarship** (£10,000), Durham University — awarded for postgraduate taught study.
- Apr 2024 **National First Prize**, 2nd "Waiwen Award" National College English Vocabulary Competition — **English Majors Division**. China Foreign Languages Publishing Administration.
  Awarded in the English Majors division as a Computer Science student.
- Jul 2024 **Second Prize (national)**, 7th National College Students' Arts Festival — Ensemble Performance, Group A. **Ministry of Education of the PRC**.
- 2023–24 **Second-Class Scholarship**, Hunan University of Finance and Economics.

Competitions

Kaggle Competitions Expert — **1,957 of 217,591** (top 0.9%) • **Notebooks Expert** — **89 of 60,915** (top 0.1%)
Both medals won **solo**: **silver**, NVIDIA Nemotron Model Reasoning Challenge (**101 of 4,185**, top 2.4%); **bronze**, Orbit Wars (**409 of 4,729**, top 8.6%).

Technical

Frameworks PyTorch, HuggingFace Transformers, scikit-learn, PyTorch Geometric

Referees and their contact details are available on request.